

Language Shift and Extinction: The Paradigm of Ikwerre in Nigeria's Linguistic Landscape

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Abstract

The Ikwerre language, an integral part of Nigeria's cultural heritage, is increasingly at risk of extinction. This study examines the underlying factors driving this trend, focusing on parental education, educational policies, and the availability of learning resources. A survey of 100 respondents, underpinned by B.F. Skinner's behaviourist theory and Halliday's environmentalist theory, reveals a strong preference for English language use, particularly among parents and in schools. This, coupled with a lack of learning materials and a perception of Ikwerre as inferior, has contributed to the language's decline. To reverse this trend, the study recommends promoting Ikwerre language use at home, integrating it into school curricula, and compiling dictionaries and novels in the language. Implementing these measures is crucial to preserving Ikwerre's cultural significance and preventing its extinction.

Keywords: *Ikwerre language, Language extinction, Language preservation, Nigeria, Endangered languages*

Introduction

Just as humans die and communities become extinct, so also do languages die and become extinct. Crystal (2008) estimates that one language is dying at somewhere in the world in every two weeks on the average. This means that many languages and language variety are facing the risk of extinction. As generally known, language is the fundamental means of communication, interactions and connection with members of different communities, thus when a language dies and goes extinct, it poses a threat to communication and interactions. Nordquist (2020) describes language extinction as "a threat to human societies" (p.4). This is because humans are social or gregarious beings and language acts as the natural force that binds members of the same community and allows them to associate with one another, thereby sustaining the society. People who speak the same language create a community for themselves and constantly interact on daily basis to promote their existence. It is because of the need to continue interacting with one another that preserving languages has become essential.

Apart from serving as a natural means of communication and social interactions, language serves as a repository of culture and Identity. Cultures and identities are created through language and are also handed down from one generation to another. Goa (2005) describes language as culture and culture as language. This shows that the relationship between language and culture is intricate and that the two of them are inseparable. On this note, it means that when

a language dies, or go extinct, the rich culture, diversity, identity of its speakers die and go extinct. The consequence of this is that human society begins to lose the beauty of their diversity (Jandt, 2003).

However, before a language becomes extinct, it must be affected by various factors and go through several stages. Crystal (2008) identifies extinction as the final stage in this process. Before reaching extinction, a language typically comes into contact with a more dominant language, loses its prestige, and becomes endangered. Nordquist (2020) explains that a language goes extinct only if no action is taken to save it during the endangered stage. This calls for the revitalization of endangered languages through policymaking and the efforts of linguists who conduct studies on endangered and extinct languages.

Studies conducted on language endangerment and extinction usually identify the possible and likely causes of language death and the factors that lead to endangerment. Such studies seek to come up with better ways to tackle language loss in contemporary societies. Agu (2018) posits that studies on language endangerment and extinction are primarily aimed at developing an effective revitalization process. Thus, such studies are not only to identify endangered languages and outline the likely causes of endangerment but also to suggest better ways to curb language loss in every human society.

The Ikwerre language has become one of the endangered languages in Rivers State, Nigeria. Cyprus (2020) posits that the Ikwerre language is endangered and facing extinction in the current time. This can be ascribed to contact with more dominant languages. Usually, when a less dominant language comes in contact with a more dominant language, the speakers of a less dominant language tend to lose prestige in their language and switch to a more dominant one. Furthermore, the vocabulary of the less dominant language can be modified by that of the more dominant one (Crystal, 2008). This can lead to the endangerment of the less dominant language because its speakers begin to reduce by each day. The Ikwerre language has come into contact with the English language and this has in turn affected the prestige which it has among its speakers. Agu (2018) posits that many young Ikwerre natives prefer speaking English to their native language because they see English as a global language.

Apart from contact with English, the Ikwerre language has also been affected by more dominant Nigerian languages such as Hausa, Yoruba, Igbo and Ibibio and Ijaw which all enjoy considerable presence in Ikwerre towns such as Port Harcourt, due to the fact that many Ikwerre towns have become urbanized. Due to the presence of speakers of other languages in Ikwerre towns, most Ikwerre speakers are forced to speak English or Nigerian Pidgin in order to communicate with people from other ethnic groups (Ezi-Nlerum & Ken Maduako, 2023). This has caused a constant reduction in the numbers of Ikwerre speakers, thus setting the language on the path of extinction.

The educational and legislative policies in Nigeria prescribe the use of English as the primary language of instruction and makes provision for the teaching of Hausa, Yoruba and Igbo in schools but do not make any provision for the use and learning of Ikwerre language and many others. Balalobi (2020) explains that the lack of recognition of many Nigerian languages in policy has heightened the overt prestige given to English, resulting in a situation where the younger generation no longer has interest in learning their indigenous languages. According to

Ezi-Nlerum and Ken-Maduako (2023), the younger generation of Ikwerre native speakers no longer have the confidence in learning and using their language. This paper therefore examines the condition of the Ikwerre language in Nigeria, its place among other languages and the causes of its endangerment.

The Ikwerre language is currently facing the threat of extinction because it has become endangered due to various sociolinguistic factors. Although many studies have been conducted on the extinction of the Ikwerre language, they have not fully addressed all the factors contributing to its gradual decline, nor the consequences of its extinction. This study, therefore, aims to contribute to the existing body of knowledge by examining the situation of the Ikwerre language, investigating additional factors responsible for its endangerment, exploring the consequences of this endangerment, and offering better solutions to address the emerging linguistic crisis in the Ikwerre community.

The aim of this study is to investigate the issue of language extinction in Nigeria, using the Ikwerre language condition as a case study and identify the factors threatening the existence of the Ikwerre language, the level to which the Ikwerre language has been endangered, examine the possible consequences of the extinction of the Ikwerre language on the Nigerian society and the people, note adequate measures that can be put in place to curb the problem.

The research is significant both in theory and practice. It is significant in theory because it provides knowledge on the social factors responsible for language endangerment and extinction and the consequences of the extinction. It acquaints the audience with some socio-linguistic concepts such as language endangerment, language policy and language revitalization, which are crucial in our understanding of language. More so, the study is useful because it connects us to the principles of language preservation/maintenance which will go a long way in preserving our culture and identity as a nation. The study also educates us on the relationship between language and culture, by making us understand that where a society loses her language, it inevitably loses her culture and identity. While appreciating the importance and role of English language in Nigeria, the study reminds us of the negative effect of English language in Nigeria, which is the extinction of our local languages.

In practice, the study is significant because it helps us to regain confidence in the use of Nigerian languages, having revealed the dangers of not using the languages. Also, it exposes the factors responsible for language extinction to, the extent to which a language can be endangered and measures adopted to revitalize an endangered language. By so doing, the research draws attention on the need to preserve various Nigerian languages as a way of preserving human cultural identities as well as the beauty of diversity. The research is also significant in practice because its findings and recommendations can be used by language policy makers to enact policies that mitigate against language extinction. The research can also serve as reference material for future researchers in the field of language endangerment and revitalization.

This article examines the Ikwerre language as an endangered language which is facing the risk of extinction. One community is selected from each of the four local government areas where Ikwerre is the indigenous language. These communities include Aluu in Ikwerre, Choba in Obi-Akpor, Oginiba in Port Harcourt and Rumuji in Emohua. The researcher does not engage in any structural, grammatical or linguistic analysis of the language, all analysis are limited to the

factors endangering the existence of the language, the extent of the endangerment, the consequences of possible extinction and the measures to adopt to mitigate further threat to the language. The limitation of the research to the scope allows the researcher complete the research within the stipulated time and within the available resources.

Literature Review

Theoretical Framework

The study is anchored on the behaviourist and environmentalist theories of language acquisition which are relevant to this study. The behaviourist theory of language was based on the work of Pavlov in the Soviet Union and of Skinner in the United States. A great deal of language teaching and learning in the 1950s and 1960s was influenced by the tenets of behaviourism. The behaviourist theory of language was based on the view that all learning, including language, occur through a process of imitation, practice, reinforcement and habit formation (Tamunobelem, 2016). Behaviourist claims that when learner's correctly produce language that approximates what they are exposed to in the input, and this effort receives positive reinforcement, habits are formed. In this view, foreign language learning is seen as a process of imitation and reinforcement, as learner's try to copy what they hear, and by regular practice, they establish a set of acceptable habits in the new language (Umera-Okeke, 2019).

According to Nlerum and Maduako (2023), the behaviourist theory is the stimulus-response (S-R) learning theory with B. F. Skinner as the eminent proponent. Skinner later came up with the concept of operant conditioning which holds the idea that behaviour is determined by its consequences which may be reinforcements or punishments. This means that the consequences of one's actions will influence him to either repeat such actions some other time or not. The theory is based upon the idea that changes in behaviour are the result of an individual's response to events (stimuli) that occur in the environment. When a particular Stimulus-Response (S-R) pattern is reinforced (rewarded), the individual is conditioned to respond. Reinforcement is the key element in Skinner's S-R theory. A reinforcer is anything that strengthens the desired response. It could be praise (like a pat on the shoulder, an applause, a bonus mark) or a good grade. Behaviour that is positively reinforced will definitely reoccur. In this case, the child is conditioned by the consequences of his action. The above assertion indicates that the essential mechanisms for the acquisition and or learning of language according to the behaviourists are imitation and practice (Nlerum & Maduako, 2023).

In a related attempt, UKessays (2018) gives a detailed explanation of the behaviourist theory. According to UKessays, behaviourism is the earliest language learning theory which is propounded by J.B. Watson (1878-1957) in 1913. This theory is supported and believed by some behaviourists who are Skinner, Pavlov and Thorndike also, profoundly developed the theory of behaviourism on learning.

Behaviourism focuses on observable behaviours which are changed as the symptoms of learning. The behaviouristic approach focuses on the immediately perceptible aspects of linguistic behaviour – the publicly observable responses. Learning only occurs when there are changes in behaviour and observable as evidence of changing. Feeling and mental process are not accepted in Skinner's human behaviour's theory; however, he still accepted the existence of

mind. Behaviourists consider learning a language as a set of mechanical habits which are formed through a process of imitation and repetition. Humans learn a language through repeating the same form and text until it becomes a habit. Children imitate the sounds and patterns which they hear around (Lightbown & Spada, 1999). So, it was proposed that learners would repeat words they heard and tried to use it in their conversation until it became a regular basis in life. Behaviourists therefore think that learning a language especially second language (L2) should be learnt through extensive drill and practice.

Besides that, behaviourists also justified that learning a new language is learning a new set of habit. According to Ellis (1990) quoted in UKessays (2018), learning could be effected by manipulating the environment to provide the required experience. This leads to the formation of habit in the environment where learning process actually takes place. These habits formation and the environment are recognized as Stimulus-Response (S-R) by Pavlov and Skinner. In 1950s, school of psychology successfully prevailed S-R in the form of behaviourism to ensure the connection between both elements. Behaviourists might consider effective language behaviour to be the production of correct responses to stimuli.

According to the theory, behaviour happens in casual, associative chains; all learning is thus characterized as associative learning, or habit formation, brought about by the repeated association of a stimulus with a response. Every process of learning has to be followed by reinforcement and all learning is the establishment of habits as the results of reinforcement and reward. In behaviourism, there are two different types of reinforcement. The first one is positive reinforcement, where the response or behaviour is strengthened and positively augmented by praise or reward. For instance, when a student answers a question correctly and the teacher awards him/her a star, then the student will try to answer another question because he/she is more confident and motivated. In contrast, the second reinforcement is negative reinforcement. If a student is scolded by his/her teacher after student got the answer wrongly, he/she would tend not to give answer another time because it would make him/her feel embarrassed. In short, positive reinforcement helps learners develop correct habits (UKessays, 2018).

The Environmentalist Theory

The environmentalist theory of language is a linguistic theory propounded by M.A.K Halliday. According to Umego (2014), the environmentalist theory expresses the view that the specific properties of language are not innate in any child, but what a child does is to depend on the environment of the language it hears around him, together with the contexts in which it is uttered for the successful learning of the language. In other words, the language acquisition of a child is activated by some factors within the environment.

Ezi-Nlerum (2023, p, 94) shares a similar view with Umego (2014) on Halliday's environmentalist theory. According to her, "the environmentalist theory of language acquisition holds that the child's language acquisition is governed by habit forming and reinforcement by imitation and repetition". This is why it is difficult to know what a child needs if he only cries without making a gesture. However, if he needs biscuit and can just point at it even while still crying and manages to say "bi-bi" as the case maybe, it becomes much easier for the caretaker to understand and attend to him. There is therefore, the tendency for the child to repeat the word „bi-bi“ when next he needs it. In this case, the mention of the word "bi-bi" reinforces the

learning and the use of the word.

The explanation according to Ezi-Nlerum (2023) is that the child's action hinges on the language prevalent in his environment since his environment is an embodiment of his upbringing. This theory holds that the environment a child finds himself affects him greatly. It is in the environment he learns to talk as he interacts with the people there. As he watches others communicate with one another, the desire to do the same thing begins to develop in him. No wonder he gradually begins to imitate and repeat the things he hears from those in his environment and before long, he learns to interact well. This means that he acquires the language of his environment whether it is his mother tongue or not. This theory goes further to state that part of the child's environment includes his parents, neighbours and siblings, and all of these people contribute to his linguistic inputs and manipulation. This means that the exposure the child receives in his environment helps to shape his language (Ezi-Nlerum, 2023).

The two theories, environmentalist and behaviourism are closely related. In the two theories, the growth of a child linguistically and otherwise takes place in the environment and the environment serves as input and his conditioning system. These theories are used in this study because they will help the researcher in accounting for some environmental factors which help some speakers of Ikwere language to fluently speak English, while abandoning their mother tongue (Ikwere language), thereby making the language to be endangered or threatened with extinction.

Conceptual Review

In this study, the researcher reviews important concepts such as the emergence of English language in Nigeria, language extinction, factors responsible for language extinction, among others.

Language Extinction/Death

According to Umera-Okeke and Ahaotu (2018, pp, 77-78), "language death is a process that affects speech communities where the level of linguistic competence that speakers possess of a given language variety is decreased, eventually resulting in no native fluent speakers of the variety". They go further to opine that a lot of indigenous languages are facing the threat of extinction in the near future as a result of the growth of the English Language. Again they observe that a lot of Nigerians in Urban cities prefer the use of the English language to their indigenous languages and that some parents view the English Language as a language of prestige and give that out to children as their first language. Consequently, they abandon the indigenous languages, thereby making them to be extinct (Umera & Ahaotu, 2018)

Campbell and Mutzel (1989) cited in Umera-Okeke (2019, p. 107) state that "language death happens when a language abruptly disappears as its native speakers are no longer found using the language". They classify language death into sudden language death, radical language death, gradual language death and bottom to top language death.

According to Crystal (2000), a language is said to be dead when no one speaks it any more. It may continue to have existence in a recorded form, of course – traditionally in writing, more recently as part of a sound or video archive but unless it has fluent speakers one would not talk of

it as a living language. And as speakers cannot demonstrate their fluency if they have no one to talk to, a language is effectively dead when there are few speakers left, with no member of the younger generation interested in learning it.

Similarly, Ezi-Nlerum (2023) holds that death occurs to a language the way it does to a man. According to her, to a layman, death and growth are natural phenomena peculiar to only living things, especially, those that are tangible and not non-living things. On the contrary, the linguists hold strongly and have shown that death can occur to a language. In fact, some languages are already endangered to the extent that there is no guarantee that such languages will still be there by the year 2050. She defines language death as a process of decrease in the level of a speech community's linguistic competence. The result is that no native or fluent speakers of the language still exists. For a language to die, there must be another language superintending over it and eventually killing it. Being introduced to a multicultural and multilingual nation like Nigeria, the English language has become the killer of so many indigenous languages, including the Ikwere (Nwala, 2016). Many languages today have gone extinct for want of speakers, a language without a group of speakers is dead (Ezi-Nlerum, 2023).

Eziwho (2020) comments that a language is said to be extinct or endangered when it is at risk of falling out of use as its speakers die out or shift to speaking another language. A language is endangered when it is on the path of extinction. A language is endangered when its speakers cease to use it; use it in an increasingly reduced number of communicative domains, and cease to pass it on from one generation to the next.

Wurm (2003) quoted in Eziwho (2020, p.145) distinguishes five levels of language endangerment (1) Potentially endangered languages, that is, if the children start preferring the dominant language; (2) Endangered, that is if the youngest speakers are young adults and only very few child speakers; (3) Seriously endangered, that is, if the youngest speakers are middle-aged or past middle age; (4) Terminally endangered or moribund, that is if there are only a few elderly speakers left; and (5) Dead, that is where there are no speakers left. Ikwere may be said to be potentially endangered if the present circumstances of the language continue to degenerate in the face of the continuing dominance of English.

Ahmed (2014, p. 46) shares the same view with Crystal (2000) as he opines that “a dead language is a language which is no longer spoken by anyone as their main language, or a language, (as in the case of Latin) that is no longer learned as a native language by a speech community”. When the last speaker of a language dies, the language too will die. Sometimes it is not necessary to wait for the last speaker to die before considering the language as dead because the last speaker has no one to speak to fluently or frequently. So, the language is extinct, as good as dead.

Mohammed (2022) in a related view notes that language goes into extinction when it lacks good number of native speakers. He notes that just like the death of human, language dies gradually. It is often stated that a language is dead even before the last native speaker of the language dies, if there are only a few elderly speakers of a language left and no longer use that language to communicate, then the language is effectively dead. A language that has reached such a reduced stage of use is generally considered dying. Half of the world's spoken languages are not being taught to new generations of children. Once a language ceases to be a native language, that is, if

children are not socialized in it as the primary language, the transmission process ends and the language itself will not survive beyond the current generations.

Causes of Language Extinction

As proposed by some scholars, there are different factors responsible for language death or extinction. Ahmed (2014) submits that language extinction or death is caused by language shift – when a language shifts towards a stronger language frequently. It also does as a result natural disasters such as volcanic eruption, hurricane, tsunami, earthquake, disease and human disasters such as invasion, genocide, warfare, political reasons such as colonization, education and migration. In other words, natural disasters that may claim the lives of people who speak a language contributes to language death. When these natural disasters kill greater number of people who speak a particular language, such language is capable of going into extinction. Also, when there the presence of a powerful language that exists alongside indigenous languages, the powerful language takes dominance, as greater population of people who speak it shifts from their native language to the foreign language which may be given the status of language of education, law, literature, media, among others (Ahmed, 2014).

Umera Okeke (2019) shares similar view by holding that language extinction in Nigeria is caused by the emergence of the English Language given the status of a global language. As a result of its global significance and its role in Nigeria as the language of education, government, media, literature, etc. Nigerian indigenes now acquire the language and use it regularly more than their indigenous languages. This makes the indigenous languages in Nigeria to die because people are gradually shifting from their language to embrace competence in the use of English Language. Umera-Okeke goes on to add that language death is caused by economic factor, and that the language of stronger economy is more preferable due to more employment opportunities and other economic advantages. Industrialization, migration and and resettlement are also instances of economic factor that may trigger language death (Umera-Okeke, 2019).

In his own view, Ravishankar (2011) sees language extinction as a consequence of colonialism. He goes on to explain that when a nation is colonized by another powerful nation, the colonizers transfer their culture to the colonized. They impose their language on the colonized nation and formulate policies that will elevate the relevance of their language. This language initiated by the colonizers begins to gain ground, making the colonized to learn it, use it and abandon their native languages. When the native language is no longer spoken by its users, it becomes extinct.

Empirical Review

There are several related works done on language extinction which this study reviewed. These works include Omego (2014), Eziwho (2020), Nlerum (2023), among others.

Omego (2014) carried out a study on the influence of environment on the child's acquisition of English language and the gradual extinction of Nigerian languages, focusing on some selected schools in Choba, Rivers State. The aim of the study was to investigate the influence of environment on the acquisition of English. The population of the study constituted forty-six teachers and 26 parents. Out of a total population of 72 respondents, 51 were sampled using the purposive sampling method. Using survey research method, the questionnaire and interview were used as research instruments. Questionnaire was administered on selected teachers and

parents to determine the influence of the social environment and peer group on the child's acquisition of English, as well as determine the effect of English language on the children's mother tongue. The study revealed that parents of the children under investigation encourage their children to use English at home alongside their mother tongues, but the children prefer to use English at play because of the multilingual setting in which they find themselves. The study also revealed that the influence of all these environmental factors leads to the gradual extinction of the child's mother tongue. This present study differs from Omegu (2014) because, while Omegu used the behaviourist and nativist theory, this study makes use of the behaviourist and environmentalist theory. Also, Omego's work focused on all the people from different tribes in Rivers State, while this study focused on people from Ikwerre ethnic nationality.

Olajoke (2018) carried out a study on the extinction of Nigerian indigenous languages, using the Yoruba language as a case study. The research was set to identify and examine the causes of language extinction, evaluate the current situation of language extinction and give possible solutions to the problem. Essential questions, in relation to the decline of the use of Yoruba language, using Ile-Ife as a case study, were addressed. The study revealed that the Ile-Ife version of Yoruba is on the path of extinction as a result of the presence of English Language. Olajoke (2018) is different from the present study because while the study focused on Yoruba language, this present study focuses on Ikwerre Language.

Toni-Duruaku and Uche (2019) carried out a study on the extinction of Nigerian indigenous languages, using the Igbo language as a case study. The study was designed to identify the factors responsible for Igbo language endangerment and the possible solution. The study identified colonial experience, quest for power, the Nigerian civil war, language policy and media programmes as some of the factors affecting the Igbo language. It recommended government intervention, preachers, scholars and researchers as factors that can help propagate the Igbo language as well as admonish errant Igbo parents within and outside Igbo land, who do not toe the line of upholding the Igbo language as factors that would revitalize endangered Igbo so that it does not go extinct. This research is different from the present research because it focused on Igbo language, whereas the present study focused on Ikwerre Language.

Eziwho (2020) carried out a study on language endangerment, with the Rumuolumeni variety of Ikwerre Language as case study. The study was aimed at describing the changes that the language has undergone, which account for endangerment. The study adopted Fisherman's and UNESCO's parameters to highlight the observation that many native speakers from forty years and above often use an English equivalent in replacement of Ikwerre words. Data for the study were collected using interview in order to determine some Ikwerre words which were still understood by the natives and those that have been endangered. The study revealed that those within the age bracket of 40 years and above speak Ikwerre fluently, while those within the age bracket of 20-39 who manage to speak Ikwerre code-switch. Sadly, those who are within the ages of two to nineteen years hardly use the language in communication situation. The study therefore raised an alarm that the Ikwerre language is on the path of extinction and therefore recommends that scholars should pay more attention to the study and proper documentation of the language. Eziwho (2020) is different from this present research in the sense that the study only focused on Rumuolumeni community, while this present study focused on four communities in Ikerre selected in each of the four local government.

In a related attempt, Ezi-Nlerum (2023) carried out a study on English as the killer of the Ikwere language spoken in Port Harcourt metropolis. The study was aimed at investigating the extent to which the English Language has endangered the Ikwere Language in Port Harcourt and to evaluate the effect of the predominant use of English Language on the Ikwere Language spoken in Port Harcourt metropolis. Data for the study were elicited from the copies of questionnaire and interview schedule as the instruments for data collection. The sample size of the study was made up of 400 respondents who were randomly selected while Taro Yamen formula was used to determine the sample size. Instruments for data analyses were frequency, percentage and mean. The study reported that English Language has actually endangered Ikwere Language which is spoken within the Port Harcourt metropolis to a very reasonable extent and that the major effect of the predominant use of English Language on the Ikwere Language was the inability of natives to communicate in their indigenous language. The study recommended that the Ikwere Language be frequently spoken at home by parents to their children and that the language should be documented to enhance its reading and writing. Ezi-Nlerum (2023) and this present study share similarity in that both works make use of behaviourist and environmentalist theory. Both works also make use of survey design. However, this present study differs from that of Ezi-Nlerum because, while she made use of purposive sampling technique, this study makes use of simple random technique. Also, the present study differs from that of Ezi-Nlerum because while she concentrated only on Port Harcourt metropolis, the present study covered all the local governments in Ikwerre by choosing at least one community from each local government. .

Methodology

This paper explains the methods used by the researcher in gathering and analyzing the data for study. The chapter is sub-divided into research design, area of study, population for the study, sample and sampling technique, research instrument/data collection, among others.

Research Design

Nworgu (1966) cited in Amadi (2018, p. 44) defines research design as a plan or blue print which specifies how data relating to a given problem are collected and analyzed. Similarly, Amadi (2018) defines research design as a road map which shows the process of gathering data from a target population through the use of various research instrument. This study makes use of survey design. A survey design is one in which a group of people or items are studied by collecting and analyzing data from only a few people or item which is considered to be a representative of the entire group or population (Ngulube, 2019). This study makes use of the survey design because it studies a group of people (Ikwerre) of which, data are got from four communities which represent the entire region of Ikwerre.

Study Area

In this research, the area under study includes four communities in Ikwerre. These communities are part of the four local governments that make up Ikwerre. One community is selected from each of the four local governments. These communities include Rumuji in Emohua, Choba in Obi-Akpor, Aluu in Ikwerre and Oginigba in Port Harcourt.

Population for the Study

The term population refers to all members of the target population of the study, which may include humans, animals and things (Nwana, 2008). But for the purpose of this study, population includes all the indigenes of the four communities selected from the four local government in Ikwerre. According to Wikipedia, the online free encyclopedia, the population of Ikwerre amounts to two million. Therefore, the population for the study is two million.

Sample and Sampling Technique

In this study, the researcher adopted simple random sampling technique. This is because it is almost impossible to study the entire population of Ikwerre. The study makes use of hundred persons that represents the entire population. These persons are selected from the four communities this:

Communities	Sample
Rumuji	25
Choba	25
Aluu	25
Oginigba	25

Nature/Sources of Data

The data used in this study are of two types: primary and secondary data. The primary data include the responses from the respondents got from the questionnaires which were administered. The secondary data for the study include ideas of linguistic scholars on language extinction got from textual materials such as journals, textbooks, dictionaries, encyclopedia and dissertations.

Method of Data Collection/Instrumentation

In order to generate data for the study, the researcher administered questionnaires and interviews to the selected communities/persons. The questionnaires were randomly distributed in order to obtain the people's opinions on issues pertaining Ikwerre Language extinction which is the thrust of this research. Also, textual materials such as textbooks, journal articles, among others, on language extinction were retrieved and used for the study.

Method of Data Analysis

The data collected were analyzed using the simple statistical method. The result of the distributed questionnaires was put in tables and their percentage worked out. The opinions of the respondents were subjected to analysis based on the number of persons who strongly agreed to the options provided in the questionnaires as regards to Ikwerre language extinction.

Discussions And Findings

The paper contains tables, which show the demographical representation of the respondents, the results of the research questions and the analysis of the results or findings. For explicitness, the

research questions precede the responses and tabular description of the responses.

Data Presentation

Table 4.1: Demographic data of respondents based on sex.

Sex	Frequency	Percentage
Females	51	51.2
Males	48	48.7 51.2
Total	99	100

Presentation and Analysis of Responses

What are the factors responsible for Ikwere language extinction?

(a) My parents use English to communicate with us at home more than they use Ikwere

Table 4.2: Responses on parental factor responsible for Ikwere language extinction.

Response	Frequency	Percentage
Strongly Agreed	50	50.5%
Agreed	46	46.4%
Disagreed	2	2%
Strongly Disagreed	1	1%
Total	99	100%

50 respondents which represents 50.5% agreed that most parents use English to communicate to their children at home more than they use Ikwere; 46 respondents which is 46.4% strongly agreed, 2 which represents 2% disagreed, while 1 which is 1% strongly disagreed. From the responses, it becomes obvious that children find it difficult to speak Ikwere because their parents do not speak it at home. This is because the number of those that strongly agreed to the opinion are more than other. This development accounts for the reason why most Ikwere children speak English more fluently than Ikwere language.

(b) Children are not allowed to speak their native language (Ikwere) in school but English.

Responses on school factor responsible for Ikere language extinction

Response	Frequency	Percentage
Strongly Agreed	59	59.5%
Agreed	34	34.3%
Disagreed	5	5.01%
Strongly Disagreed	1	1.01%
Total	99	100%

From the table above, it could be seen that 59 respondents which represent 59.5% strongly agreed that schools do not allow students to speak Ikwerre language but English; 34 which is 34.3% agreed, 5 (5%) disagreed while 1 (1%) respondent strongly disagreed. From their responses, it becomes clear that schools contribute to the extinction of Ikwerre language by not allowing the children and encouraging them to use their native language. This is confirmed by the highest number of respondents who strongly agreed to the opinion.

(c) Children from Ikwerre whose parents are from another tribe may speak the language of their mother instead of Ikwerre.

Responses on marriage factors responsible for Ikwerre language extinction.

Response	Frequency	Percentage
Strongly Agreed	46	46.4%
Agreed	45	45.4%
Disagreed	6	6.06%
Strongly Disagreed	2	2.02%
Total	99	100%

From the responses above, 46 respondents representing 46.4% strongly agreed that there is possibility of children from Ikwerre whose mothers are from another tribe speaking the language of their mothers instead of Ikwerre; 46 which is 45.4% strongly agreed, 6 representing 6%, disagreed, while 1 respondent (1%) strongly disagreed. The highest number of respondents (46) who strongly agreed to the opinion justifies the fact that inter-ethnic marriage initiates the extinction of Ikwerre language, since children whose parents are involved in inter-ethnic marriage may be influenced by their mothers' language, thereby abandoning their native language. Therefore, because the number of respondents who strongly agreed to the opinion is more than others, it is then accepted that inter-ethnic marriage initiates the extinction of Ikwerre language.

(d) Most Ikwerre children are considered being local when using their native language more fluent than English.

Responses on Ikwere language debasement responsible for its extinction.

Response	Frequency	Percentage
Agreed	49	49.4%
Strongly Agreed	27	27.2%
Disagreed	6	6.06%
Strongly Disagreed	2	2.02%
Total	99	100%

From the table above, 49 (49.4%) respondents strongly agreed, 27(27.2%) respondents agreed, 6 (6%) disagreed while 2 (2) strongly disagreed that most Ikwere children are considered being local when using their native language more fluent than English. The highest number of respondents who agreed and strongly agreed to the opinion are higher than others. Therefore, it is accepted that most children from Ikwere are considered local for speaking their language. This accounts for the reason most children from Ikwere prefer English, since they do not want to be called local children who delight in using inferior Ikwere language.

Research question 2: What are the effects of Ikwere language extinction?

(a) Majority of Ikwere children cannot speak their language

Responses on children's loss of Ikwere language

Response	Frequency	Percentage
Strongly Agreed	51	51.5%
Agreed	32	32.4%
Disagreed	6	6%
Strongly Disagreed	-	-
Total	99	100%

From the data above, one can see that 51 respondents which is 51.5% strongly agreed that majority of Ikwere children cannot speak their language; 32 which is 32.4% agreed while none strongly disagreed. Since the highest number of respondents who strongly agreed to the opinion is more than others, it is therefore confirmed that Ikwere language is on the path of extinction since majority of Ikwere children cannot use their language.

(b) Most children from Ikwere do not have the knowledge of Ikwere culture since they cannot speak the language.

Responses on Ikwerre children's loss of culture due to loss of language.

Response	Frequency	Percentage
Strongly Agreed	64	64.6%
Agreed	32	32.3%
Disagreed	3	3.0%
Strongly Disagreed	-	-
Total	99	100%

From the responses above, it is clear that 64 which is 54.6% respondents strongly agreed that most children from Ikwerre do not have the knowledge of their culture since they cannot speak Ikwerre; 32 which is 32.3% agreed, 3 which is 3% disagreed, while none strongly disagreed to the opinion. Since the highest number of respondents who strongly agreed to the opinion is more than other respondents, it is therefore justified that the loss of language results in the loss of culture, pointing to the fact that just like Ikwerre language, Ikwerre culture is dying.

© If Ikwerre language dies, generations to come may not have access to the language or culture.

Responses on generational loss of Ikwerre language

Response	Frequency	Percentage
Strongly Agreed	65	65.6%
Agreed	14	14%
Disagreed	15	15.1%
Strongly Disagreed	5	5.05%
Total	99	100%

From the table above, it is observed that 65 respondents making up 65.6% strongly agreed that If Ikwerre language dies, generations to come may not have access to the language or culture; 14 which is 14% agreed, 15 which is 15% disagreed, while 5 which is 5% strongly disagreed to the opinion. The highest number of respondents strongly agreed to the opinion more than other respondents, justifying the fact that If Ikwerre language dies, generations to come may not have access to the language or culture. Therefore, if nothing is done about Ikwerre language extinction, a time will come when there will be none left to speak the language.

(d) Other languages spoken in Ikwerre region may give those tribes access to dominate Ikwerre in terms of language, education and culture.

Responses on linguistic dominance of Ikwere language.

	Frequency	Percentage
Strongly Agreed	59	59.5%
Agreed	34	34.3%
Disagreed	5	5.05
Strongly Disagreed	1	1.0%
Total	99	100%

From the table, it is seen that majority of the respondents (59) which is 59.5% strongly agreed that other languages spoken in Ikwere region may give those tribes access to dominate Ikwere in terms of language, education and culture; 34 making up 34.3% respondents agreed, 5 disagreed, while 1 strongly disagreed. For the highest number of respondents to strongly agree to the opinion, it then means that, of a truth, other languages spoken in Ikwere region will give those tribes access to dominate Ikwere in terms of language, education and culture.

What are the solutions to Ikwere language extinction?

(a) For Ikwere language to exist, it must compulsorily be taught in schools.

Responses on teaching Ikwere language as a solution to its extinction.

Response	Frequency	Percentage
Strongly Agreed	73	73.7%
Agreed	25	25.2%
Disagreed	1	-
Strongly Disagreed	-	-
Total	99	100%

The highest number of respondents (73) which is 73.7% strongly agreed that For Ikwere language to exist, it must compulsorily be taught in schools; 25 which is 25.2% agreed, 1 respondent disagreed, while none disagreed to the opinion. The number of those who strongly agreed to the opinion is more than number of respondents who disagreed and strongly disagreed, Thereby confirming that for Ikwere language to exist, it must compulsorily be taught in schools. This makes it possible for students to master its vocabulary, syntax and semantics and use it fluently in communication.

(b) Parents should be compelled to use Ikwere while communicating with their children at home.

Responses on parents' frequent use of Ikwere as a solution to its extinction.

Response	Frequency	Percentage
Strongly Agreed	60	60.6%
Agreed	28	28.2%
Disagreed	1	1.0%
Strongly Disagreed	-	0%
Total	99	100%

From the responses, 60 respondents which is 60.6% strongly agreed that parents should be compelled to use Ikwere while communicating with their children at home; 28 which is 28.2% agreed, 1 disagreed, while none strongly disagreed to the opinion. The highest number of respondents strongly agreed to the opinion more than other respondents. This confirms that parents should be compelled to use Ikwere while communicating with their children at home. This will help the children to be acquainted with the words and sentences in Ikwere since they will hear it everyday. With this, they become reinforced in the language and automatically acquire it.

(d) Some Ikwere linguists should strive to write Ikwere dictionary, write novels so that people will gradually master the language.

Responses on the codification of Ikwere as a solution to its extinction.

Response	Frequency	Percentage
Strongly Agreed	50	50.5%
Agreed	36	36.3%
Disagreed	10	10.1%
Strongly Disagreed	3	3.0%
Total	99	100%

50 respondents which is 50.5% strongly agreed that some Ikwere linguists should strive to write Ikwere dictionary, write novels so that people will gradually master the language. 36 respondents which is 36.3% agreed; 10 respondents which is 10% disagreed, while 3 disagreed. Since the highest number of respondents strongly agreed, it is therefore confirmed that This is because literature contributes to the mastery of language. Children who read these novels or texts in Ikwere will be introduced to some terms in Ikwere. They may even be opportuned to look out for the meaning of some Ikwere words if dictionaries are available.

Discussion of Findings

Having administered the questionnaire to the respondents and having seen their opinions so far on the subject of Ikwere language extinction, it is discovered and agreed that Ikwere language is

on the path of extinction because it is noticing great reduction in the number of its speakers. Those born from 2000 to this present day can hardly use the language fluently during conversation. This issue of Ikwere language extinction as the findings reveal is caused by a number of some factors.

Firstly, as shown in table 4.2, most Ikwere parents find it difficult to use Ikwere to communicate to their children, as they prefer using English language. These parents consider it worthwhile for their children to be more fluent in English than Ikwere, believing that those who speak English fluently stand to gain much benefits, since English is considered as a global language. This belief of theirs manifests in their use of English when communicating to their children.

Secondly, in table 4.3, it is confirmed that some schools contribute to the extinction of Ikwere language. This is seen in the way schools do not allow children to use their native language in school. Most of these schools may go to the extent of punishing children who use their native language in school. Children report several cases in which they are asked to write the names of those who use their native language in school. Consequently, most children (including those from Ikwere) grow with the mentality that speaking their native language is bad or something considered a local behaviour.

Finally, table 4.4 shows that inter-ethnic marriage contributes greatly to Ikwere language extinction. Majority of Ikwere men who got married to women of other tribes play little or no role in teaching their children Ikwere language. As a result of this, their children quickly adapt to their mothers' language. This account for the reason we may see Ikwere indigenes who cannot speak their language but speak their mothers' language fluently.

The consequences of the extinction of Ikwere language is that most children from Ikwere cannot speak their native language. This may also affect generation unborn who may have no one left to teach them the language. (see table 4.5 and 4.6). Since language helps in the expression of culture, table 4.8 informs that they may not also be able to express their culture. This therefore points to the fact that Ikwere is not only losing their language but also their culture. This ugly development gives room for other tribes whose languages flourish in Ikwere to dominate them in terms of language and culture.

Conclusion

The issue of language extinction is a plague that pervades the Nigerian local languages that become extinct alongside the culture they express. The aim of this article was to investigate the subject of Nigerian language extinction, using Ikwere language as a case study. The research was designed to achieve objectives which were to examine the causes of the language extinction, its effects and the possible solutions. This gave rise to some research questions on the causes of Ikwere language extinction, its effects and the possible solution. Providing answers to these questions makes the study significant in that it will help reveal the factors responsible for language extinction and how to deal with those factors. This paper looked at related works done language extinction. Behaviourist and environmentalist theories were used which helped in accounting for behavioral and environmental factors responsible for the extinction of Ikwere language and how some factors as well can initiate its acquisition. Important concepts such language death/extinction and the causes of language extinction. The research methodology. It

explains the various means used in gathering the research data. Using the survey design, the researcher was able to study hundred respondents from four Ikwerre communities selected in each of the local government, which represented the entire population of Ikwerre. Hundred copies of questionnaires were distributed in order to get the responses from the respondents. The findings of the research reveal that Ikwerre language is on the path of extinction because some parents find it difficult to use Ikwerre when communicating with their children; most schools discourage Ikwerre children from using their language too. The effect of these lies in the children's inability to use Ikwerre language and to also have knowledge of Ikwerre culture. This makes them appear like strangers in their own native land.

This study is an investigation of Ikwerre language extinction. It examines the factors responsible for the extinction, effect of the extinction and solution to the extinction. Having investigated the said issue, it is discovered that Ikwerre language is endangered as it notices a reduction in the number of speakers. This is due to the fact that children are no longer exposed to the language due to the domineering power of English language. Also, other powerful languages within have gradually shifted the native languages as well as the culture they are tied to. These neighbouring languages often came as a result of inter-ethnic marriage which influenced most Ikwerre children to embrace their mothers' languages instead of Ikwerre.

Recommendation.

This study examines the issue of extinction of Nigerian Indigenous languages, using Ikwerre as a case study. Having investigated the problem, it is discovered that Ikwerre language is on the path of extinction due to the fact that some parents do not speak Ikwerre language but English to their children; schools discourage children from speaking the language. Also, the issue of inter-ethnic marriage plays major role in the extinction of Ikwerre language. To solve this problem, this study therefore recommends parents should make sure they speak Ikwerre language at home so that their children will master it. Also, the government should make sure that native languages are taught in schools, so that Ikwerre students will have the opportunity of learning their language. Again, Ikwerre fathers who are married to women outside Ikwerre tribe should make sure their children are exposed to the language. They can achieve this by sending the children to their village during school holidays. Finally, Ikwerre linguists should endeavour to compile dictionaries in Nigerian native languages. These would help in the sustenance of Ikwerre/Nigerian native languages.

Contribution to Knowledge

The study on the extinction of Ikwerre language contributes to existing body of knowledge. Previous factors that examined the issues of Ikwerre language extinction emphasized on the domineering power of English and other neighbouring languages as the factors responsible for the extinction of Ikwerre language. This research agrees with the previous on the said factors. However, this present research discovers that inter-ethnic marriage is a powerful factor that activates the Ikwerre language extinction. Children from Ikwerre whose mothers are from other tribes are greatly influenced by the mothers' language. They easily acquire their mothers' language and pay little or no attention to Ikwerre. Discovering this factor will enable Ikwerre fathers to provide means of enabling their children come in contact with Ikwerre language.

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